

• glossary

a posteriori

Knowledge is a posteriori if it requires experience of particular features of the world.

a posteriori reductive naturalism

The view that ethical facts can be reduced to natural facts by empirical discovery (rather than conceptual analysis).

a priori

Knowledge is a priori if it does not require experience of particular features of the world.

action theory

This is the area of philosophy (part metaphysics and part philosophy of mind) that investigates the nature of action, especially how mental states and reasons figure in action.

akrasia

Thinking that one ought to ϕ (or that ϕ -ing would be overall best), but lacking sufficient (or, in the extreme, all) motivation to ϕ .

all-things-considered normativity

The reasons or 'ought's that result from not just ethical, prudential, epistemological, etc. considerations but from all relevant considerations.

anthropological relativism

The anthropological claim that different groups of people adhere to different norms or ways of living together. (Contrast metaethical relativism.)

antirealism

This is the denial of realism.

antirepresentationalism

This is the denial of representationalism.

argument from queerness, the

A family of arguments due to Mackie for the error theory based on the idea that ethical facts can't really obtain because they would have to be too weird to fit into our standard pictures of reality and human knowledge.

argument from relativity

Mackie's argument for the error theory that is based on the idea that ethical beliefs vary across the world.

attributive adjective

Geach's label for a term such as 'big' that gets its meaning in particular sentences from the way it modifies a subsequent term (e.g. "big flea") in forming a predicate rather than providing freestanding content. (Contrast predicative adjective.)

belief–desire psychology of motivation

This is another name for the Humean theory of motivation.

besire

The name given to the supposed inseparable amalgam of a belief and a desire.

Canberra Plan

A term for using a priori network analyses to understand key philosophical concepts.

causal theory of reference

The view that the referent of a word is determined by causal (and so historical) connections to things in reality (rather than by the descriptions associated with the word).

characteristic ways of living

Something like a function which might determine what traits are virtues for a particular kind of living thing.

cognitivism

This is the view that ethical judgment culminates in belief.

coherentist conception of knowledge

The view in epistemology that knowledge is based on the coherence of our beliefs in a wide network or system of mutually supporting beliefs.

compositionality assumption

The assumption at the heart of theories of meaning which says that the meaning of wholes (e.g., sentences) is a function of the meaning of its parts (e.g., words) and how these parts are put together.

conservationist

A form of error theory that says that we should continue to use ethical or normative concepts even though their application is in error, contrasting with Mackie's eliminativist stance towards ethical concepts.

constructivism

The view that some realm of facts isn't "out there" for discovery but rather "constructed" by some procedure or standpoint.

contextualism

A family of views in epistemology that hold that what it takes to truly attribute knowledge varies from context to context, allowing for a spectrum of contexts from high standards to low standards.

convenient fiction

Something we don't believe to be precisely true but pretend to be true because it is convenient for various purposes.

conventional implicature

What is conveyed by the use of a sentence in virtue of linguistic conventions, though not part of its literal content.

conversational implicature

What is conveyed by the use of a sentence given contextual clues, though not part of its literal content.

correspondence theory of truth

The view that a sentence *S* is true in virtue of corresponding to some piece of reality, the fact that *S*.

directions of fit

This is Anscombe's metaphor now commonly used to divide between representational mental states such as belief and goal-setting mental states such as desires and intentions.

divine command theory

The view that moral facts are constituted by the commands of some supreme being.

ecumenical expressivist

Someone defending the view that ethical sentences express, as a function of their meaning, both belief-like and desire-like mental states.

emotive meaning

The emotional connotations of a term or statement, contrasted with factual meaning.

empirical investigation

This is the way we come to know things about reality through observing the world around us. We do this in a mundane way all the time; but science is also built on more precise empirical observation, involving forming and testing hypotheses.

epistemic modal

A word such as 'might' used to qualify the modal status of the content it embeds with respect to evidence.

epistemology

This is the area of philosophy concerned with knowledge and justification for our beliefs.

error theory

This is the metaethical view that holds that ethical judgments (at least the simple ones) attempt to represent reality but fail because there are no ethical facts.

ethical judgments

These are first-order claims about what is right/wrong, good/bad, virtuous/vicious, etc. Metaethics doesn't consist in making and defending ethical judgments, but rather asking about the practice of making them.

ethical virtues

Character traits that make one an ethically good person.

expressivism

This is the metaethical view that holds that ethical statements are not straightforward expressions of beliefs about reality but instead get their meaning from being the expression of nonbelief attitudes.

externalism about justifying reasons

This is the view that a consideration (or fact) can be a reason for someone to act even if it doesn't bear that person's desires, preferences, or plans, or even on those they would have were they suitably well-informed and logically consistent in their mental states.

fallacy of equivocation

The fallacy of inferring in a way that trades on assigning two different meanings to terms of the argument.

fictionalism

This is the metaethical view that ethical sentences are used as a kind of convenient fiction, not literally true but usefully treated as true.

foundationalist conception of knowledge

The view in epistemology that knowledge is based on our beliefs being supported, ultimately, by some foundational beliefs or experiences.

Frege–Geach problem

The multifaceted challenge to expressivists stemming from Frege's observation that a sentence's content can occur in asserted contexts (such as statements) as well as unasserted contexts (such as the antecedent of a conditional or in an interrogative).

functional kinds

Something that can be classified in terms of its function, e.g., doorstop.

Gettier problem

A famous challenge to the JTB analysis of knowledge, illustrating cases where someone could have a justified true belief but doesn't seem to have knowledge.

global expressivism

The idea that all language—not just ethical language—expresses noncognitive attitudes rather than beliefs about reality.

Hume's Law

The idea that one cannot derive an 'ought' from an 'is.'

Humean theory of motivation

This is the view that motivation to act always involves the cooperation of two kinds of mental states, one with a goal-setting direction of fit and the other with a reality-representing direction of fit.

hybrid cognitivist

Someone defending the view that ethical statements express both a belief about some ethical fact and also a desire-like attitude.

implicature

The phenomenon whereby meaning is conveyed by the use of a sentence even though it is not part of the literal content of the sentence. (See conversational implicature and conventional implicature.)

implicit parameter

A logical parameter in the meaning of a sentence taking different values in different contexts of use, but not showing up explicitly as an indexical word in the sentence.

indexical

A word that refers to different things in different contexts of use in a systematic way; e.g., 'now,' 'here.'

inference to the best explanation

When we infer something because it provides the best explanation of something else. Sometimes called "abductive" reasoning to contrast it with deductive and inductive reasoning.

instrumentally

The relation between means and ends.

internalism about justifying reasons

This is the view that a consideration (or fact) cannot be a reason for someone to act unless it bears on one of their desires, preferences, or plans, or would do were they suitably well-informed and logically consistent in their mental states.

intrinsically motivating

The idea that something could be such that just recognizing it would move our wills.

intuition

A faculty of mind distinguished from empirical observation and reasoning. This is commonly appealed to by ethical nonnaturalists in an explanation of how we can come to know ethical facts.

intuitionism

This is the view that we know ethical facts through a special faculty of intuition.

justifying reasons

These are the considerations (or facts) that legitimate an action (insofar as it is legitimate).

knowledge-first epistemology

A movement in epistemology based on the idea that knowledge is a more fundamental epistemic concept than justification or evidence, suggesting that we shouldn't try to analyze knowledge.

linguistic turn

This was a period in the history of philosophy (early twentieth century) when philosophers became increasingly interested in language and sought solutions to longstanding philosophical problems through linguistic analysis.

meaning fictionalist

Someone defending the view that the meaning of the sentences in some area of discourse is implicitly relativized to a fiction.

metaepistemology

The investigation into meta-level issues about epistemic judgments that parallels metaethics.

metaethical relativism

The view that there's no such thing as ethical right/wrong, full stop, but only ethical right/wrong relative to some culture, morality, social agreement, etc. (Contrast anthropological relativism.)

metaethics

This is the area of the philosophical study of ethics where we move to a more abstract level to ask about the first-order practice of making ethical judgments, which leads to various questions in metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind.

metanormative theory

The extension of meta-level questions from metaethics to normativity in general.

metaphysics

This is the area of philosophy concerned with what exists and the nature of reality.

minimalist theory of truth

The view that the truth predicate does not carry heavy duty metaphysical commitments but rather figures in any area of discourse with contentful declarative sentences.

missionary and cannibals example

Hare's famous example meant to motivate the idea that ethical terms prescribe and evaluate rather than pick out the empirical or factual characteristic of things.

moral disagreement

This is when two people's views about morality stand in tension and that tension is not due to some underlying factual disagreement.

moral psychology

This is the area of philosophy concerned with the psychology involved in motivation to act, especially in contexts where one has made an ethical judgment about the action.

moral skeptic

Someone who doubts that we have any moral knowledge.

Moral Twin Earth Thought Experiment

The thought experiment where we imagine a twin world, exactly like the actual world, but different properties casually sustain the use of our ethical terms. This was introduced by Horgan and Timmons (drawing on a similar example Putnam used in a different context) to argue that a posteriori naturalism is problematic.

motivating reasons

These are the mental states that explain why someone did what they did in the sense of *rationalizing* it.

motivational externalism

This is the view that ethical judgment alone cannot play the role of a motivational state of mind but rather requires the support of some further state of mind (such as a desire or preference) to generate motivation.

motivational internalism

This is the view that ethical judgment can play the role of a motivational state of mind.

naturalism

This can refer to a general view in metaphysics that the only facts that obtain are natural facts or the more specific view in metaethics that ethical facts are natural facts.

naturalistic fallacy

The supposed fallacy of identifying something's ethical qualities with the natural qualities in virtue of which it has those ethical qualities. Moore argued that views like Utilitarianism commit this because they identify being good with causing pleasure.

naturalistic worldview

The idea that all that exists is what is natural.

natures

Neo-Aristotelians argue that facts about things' natures might be viewed as natural facts capable of underpinning ethical facts.

Neo-Aristotelians

Philosophers such as Foot and Hursthouse who try to revive ideas from Aristotle in arguing for a kind of metaethical naturalism.

network-style analysis

A kind of conceptual analysis that seeks not to break concepts down into their component parts but rather identify the network connecting a class of concepts. Jackson used this to develop a new form of a priori naturalism, not subject to Moore's open-question argument.

noncognitivism

This is the view that ethical judgment culminates in some nonbelief attitude such as a desire, intention, plan, or preference.

nonnaturalism

This is the metaethical view that holds that ethical facts are not reducible to facts of some other sort (such as natural or supernatural facts).

norm-expressivism

The view Gibbard defended according to which ethical statements express commitments to norms which rule some actions in and other actions out.

normative epistemology

The epistemic analog of normative ethics.

normative ethics

This is the area of the philosophical study of ethics where we attempt to come up with general theories to classify things as ethically right/wrong, good/bad, virtuous/vicious, etc.

normativity

Involving norms, rules, or reasons.

objectively prescriptive

The idea that some facts provide reasons for agents to act irrespective of their desires, cares, or concerns.

ontological commitments

What a theory is committed to about what entities are part of reality.

open-question argument

The argument first developed by Moore for ethical nonnaturalism based on the fact that one can wonder whether something that is *N* is good, for any natural property *N*, without displaying conceptual confusion.

original position

Rawls' term for the hypothetical choice situation where, behind a veil of ignorance about where in society one might end up, fair principles of justice might be chosen.

partners-in-crime response

A style of philosophical objection which suggests that if a critical claim about something (e.g., ethics) is correct then it would also have to be correct about something else (the "partner") that we are less willing to grant (e.g., mathematics).

permutation problem

An objection that network-style analyses are potentially open to based on the idea that some networks of concepts could be satisfied by different constellations of properties, each comprising a systematic permutation on the others.

philosophy of language

This is the area of philosophy concerned with explaining how language has meaning and characterizing various aspects of the use of language.

philosophy of mind

This is the area of philosophy concerned with all phenomena mental. In metaethics, the relevant mental phenomena are the psychology of motivation and the connection between our minds and having reasons to act.

practical ethics

This is the area of the philosophical study of ethics where we attempt to reach practical conclusions about what someone should do in the face of particular ethical questions.

pragmatics

This is the study of the way language is used for various effects.

pragmatism

The movement in philosophy emphasizing our practices with words and concepts rather than what they refer to in reality.

predicative adjective

Geach's label for a term such as 'red' that contributes freestanding meaning in particular sentences rather than depending on the way it modifies some other term. (Contrast attributive adjective.)

prescription

This is a category of speech-acts involving telling someone what to do (for instance, commanding, entreating, suggesting, advising, etc.). Sometimes this term is also used to refer to vehicles (e.g., imperative sentences) that are distinctively usable to perform the related speech-act.

prescriptivism

Hare's theory of ethical language according to which ethical statements do not describe matters of fact but rather make "universalized" prescriptions.

principle of charity

The counsel to start out with the presumption that most of what someone says is true, requiring explanation for false beliefs rather than true ones.

principle of parsimony

The idea that, of two explanations of some phenomena, the one appealing to fewer sui generis things is preferable, all other things being equal.

projectivist

Someone defending the view that ethical statements “guild and stain” reality rather than track features existing independently of human interaction with reality.

quasi-realism

Blackburn’s program of earning the right for expressivists to use terms in conjunction with ethical discourse that had traditionally been assumed to be markers of representationalism and cognitivism, such as ‘true,’ ‘believes,’ and ‘fact.’ It involves adopting a minimalist stance towards these terms.

radical skepticism

The view in epistemology that there isn’t and couldn’t be knowledge (and/or justified belief).

rationalism

A way of developing ideal observer accounts of ethical truth, where it’s the observer’s ethical beliefs that matter.

realism

It is difficult to define this precisely, but realism about *X* is roughly the view that *X* facts obtain objectively (or equivalently, that *X* properties are objectively instantiated). So *moral realism* is the view that ethical facts obtain objectively.

representationalism

This is the view that an area of discourse (e.g., ethical discourse) purports to be about something in reality.

representations

Various linguistic and mental items can be vehicles for depicting or standing for something assumed to be real; doing so is to be a representation.

scientism

A derisory term for those who think science is the ultimate arbiter of what’s real.

semantics

This is the study of the meaning of words and the sentences they can be used to form.

sentimentalism

A way of developing ideal observer accounts of ethical truth, where it’s the observer’s moral sentiments that matter.

speech-act fictionalist

Someone defending the view that the statements made in some area of discourse aren’t really assertions expressing beliefs in some matter of fact, but rather the performance of some other speech-act such as pretense or loose speak.

subjectivism

An extreme form of relativism that holds that ethical right/wrong are relative to individual subjectivities.

sui generis

This Latin term means “of its own kind” and it is used in metaethics to characterize the views of nonnaturalists who think ethical facts are of their own kind (and not reducible; e.g., to natural or supernatural facts).

supervenience

The relation holding of two domains of facts or properties when there cannot be differences in the first domain (e.g., ethics) without differences in the second domain (e.g., facts about benefits and harms). Although every domain trivially supervenes on itself, supervenience is weaker than identity or reducibility.

theoretical cost–benefit analysis

This is one of the main methods of metaethics, whereby one evaluates the relative attractiveness of various theories by tallying their costs and benefits along fixed dimensions of one’s theoretical concern.

truth-apt

A sentence is truth-apt when it can properly be said to be true or false, i.e. it can be used in such a way that it makes sense to embed it in “It’s true/false that...”

veil of ignorance

Rawls’ term for the suppression of personal and individualistic information that will put one in a better position to choose fair principles of justice.

verificationist principle

The principle that the meaning of a sentence is its verification conditions.